Tertiary Infotech Academy Pte Ltd

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LEARNER GUIDE

For

ISO 9001 Quality Management System (QMS) Internal Auditor Training

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8.0	Legacy release	Legacy trainer slide deck and supporting documents.	Tertiary Infotech Academy
9.0	12 August 2026	Complete visual rebuild; current ISO 19011:2026 status; expanded audit methods, evidence analysis, case activities and aligned assessments.	Dr Alfred Ang

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How to Use This Guide

The slide deck is concept-led. This guide carries the detailed procedures, scenarios, questions, evidence requirements and acceptance checks for all eight activities. Each activity also has a self-contained folder under activities/ with a working Excel workbook and printable PDF/checklist.

Use only fictional, anonymised or authorised workplace information. Apply independence, confidentiality, due professional care and evidence-based judgement throughout.

Course Learning Outcomes

- LO1: Conduct ISO 9001 internal audit activities using appropriate methodologies and tools to ensure organisational compliance.
- LO2: Analyse audit findings to identify process inefficiencies, non-compliance issues and areas for improvement.
- LO3: Propose actionable improvement plans to mitigate identified risks and non-compliance issues.
- LO4: Implement updated audit procedures following changes in internal compliance standards or external regulatory guidelines.

Competency Alignment

Code	Competency requirement
K1	Methodologies and tools for the conduct of audit activities
K2	Interpretation and analysis of audit results
K3	Identification of non-compliance
K4	Internal and external compliance and regulatory guidelines
A1	Conduct audit activities in line with organisational compliance processes and guidelines using appropriate methodologies and tools
A2	Analyse audit results and highlight process gaps or key instances of non-compliance
A3	Propose improvements to compliance processes and measures that address major risks
A4	Implement changes in audit performance in alignment with internal standards or external regulatory guidelines

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Current Standards Baseline

- ISO 9001:2015 with Amendment 1:2024 remains the current published QMS requirements edition on 12 August 2026.
- ISO 9001:2026 is under publication and expected in September 2026. Draft or preview text is not a binding requirement.
- ISO 19011:2026, published in May 2026, is the current management-system auditing guidance.
- Confirm the applicable edition, amendment, legal obligation, contract and organisational procedure before every audit.

Topic 01 — Introduction to Audit Activities and Compliance Methodologies

Alignment: K1 · A1 · LO1

QMS foundations · ISO 9001:2015/Amd 1:2024 · ISO 19011:2026 · audit planning

Quality, conformity and effectiveness

- **Quality:** Degree to which inherent characteristics fulfil requirements.
- **Conformity:** A requirement is fulfilled; evidence must show the match.
- **Effectiveness:** Planned activities are realised and intended results achieved.
- **Efficiency:** Results are achieved with proportionate use of resources.

Auditor application

- Audit both implementation and results
- Follow requirements into real work
- Use customer and process measures
- Recognise effective controls

Judgement cautions

- Do not equate quality with premium grade
- A document alone is not effectiveness
- One good sample is not system proof
- Cost cutting can damage conformity

Quality control, assurance and the QMS

- **Quality control:** Operational techniques detect whether outputs meet acceptance criteria.
- **Quality assurance:** Planned controls provide confidence that requirements will be fulfilled.
- **QMS:** Interrelated policies, processes, roles and resources direct and control quality.

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- **Internal audit:** Independent assurance tests conformity and effectiveness across that system.

Auditor application

- Trace from policy to process to output
- Test preventive and detective controls
- Evaluate interfaces between functions
- Report system implications

Judgement cautions

- Inspection cannot replace process control
- The quality team does not own all quality
- Certification does not guarantee every output
- Audit is not operational supervision

Seven quality management principles

- **Customer focus:** Understand needs, fulfil requirements and monitor perception.
- **Leadership and people:** Align direction, resources, competence and engagement.
- **Process and evidence:** Manage connected processes and make decisions from reliable information.
- **Improvement and relationships:** Learn continually and manage relevant stakeholder relationships.

Auditor application

- Use principles to interpret system intent
- Ask how leadership enables quality
- Link measures to decisions
- Look for learning across boundaries

Judgement cautions

- Principles are not auditable clauses by themselves
- No fixed priority fits every organisation
- Slogans do not prove deployment
- Supplier accountability cannot be outsourced

Process approach and system interactions

- **Purpose:** Define the result and the customer or interested party served.
- **Inputs and outputs:** Identify what enters, transforms and leaves the process.
- **Controls and resources:** Clarify methods, competence, infrastructure, criteria and records.
- **Interfaces and measures:** Manage hand-offs, ownership, risks and performance indicators.

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Auditor application

- Audit in process sequence
- Trace end-to-end transactions
- Test hand-off controls
- Compare results with objectives

Judgement cautions

- Clause-by-clause interviews fragment the system
- Department boundaries hide process gaps
- Too many measures obscure performance
- Undefined ownership weakens action

PDCA and risk-based thinking

- **Plan:** Set objectives, processes, resources, risks and controls.
- **Do:** Operate processes under planned and controlled conditions.
- **Check:** Monitor, measure, analyse, audit and review performance.
- **Act:** Correct, improve, standardise and update the system.

Auditor application

- Use risk to set audit priority
- Test whether planned controls operated
- Compare evidence with intended results
- Follow learning into system changes

Judgement cautions

- ISO 9001 does not mandate a formal risk register
- Risk treatment should be proportionate
- Audits are only one Check mechanism
- Correction alone does not prevent recurrence

ISO 9000 family and current status

- **ISO 9000:** Fundamentals and vocabulary that support consistent interpretation.
- **ISO 9001:** Requirements for a QMS; the certifiable standard in the family.
- **ISO 9004:** Guidance for sustained organisational success beyond minimum conformity.
- **ISO 19011:2026:** Current guidance on audit principles, programmes, conduct and competence.

Auditor application

- Audit against applicable requirements
- Use ISO 19011 as guidance

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- Confirm contract/regulation versions
- Track standards transitions

Judgement cautions

- ISO 19011 is not a certification standard
- Do not audit against withdrawn editions
- Draft standards are not requirements
- Guidance does not override law or contract

ISO 9001:2015 and the 2024 climate amendment

- **Current edition:** ISO 9001:2015 remains current on 12 August 2026.
- **Amendment 1:2024:** Context consideration now explicitly includes climate-change relevance.
- **Interested parties:** Relevant parties may have climate-related requirements.
- **2026 revision:** The next edition is under publication and expected in September 2026.

Auditor application

- Verify relevance was considered
- Follow relevant needs into controls
- Monitor official publication
- Plan a controlled gap review

Judgement cautions

- Do not invent a mandatory climate programme
- Do not teach draft text as final
- A one-line statement may lack evidence
- Transition rules come from official sources

Clause structure: context to improvement

- **4-5:** Context establishes the system; leadership directs and owns it.
- **6:** Planning addresses risks, opportunities, objectives and changes.
- **7-8:** Support enables controlled operation and product/service provision.
- **9-10:** Evaluation creates evidence; improvement reacts, corrects and learns.

Auditor application

- Follow the PDCA logic across clauses
- Map requirements to processes
- Test interaction, not isolated ownership
- Use clause references precisely

Judgement cautions

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- Clauses 1-3 provide scope and terms
- Not every requirement needs a procedure
- Applicability needs justification
- A clause checklist is only a prompt

Context, interested parties and QMS scope

- **Issues:** Determine internal and external matters relevant to QMS purpose and direction.
- **Interested parties:** Identify relevant parties and relevant requirements.
- **Climate relevance:** Explicitly decide whether climate change is a relevant issue.
- **Scope:** Define boundaries, applicability, products/services and justification.

Auditor application

- Review evidence of monitoring and review
- Test how needs become requirements
- Visit physical and virtual boundaries
- Challenge unsupported non-applicability

Judgement cautions

- Long stakeholder lists may add no value
- Scope must match actual operations
- Outsourced work remains controlled
- Marketing scope and certified scope may differ

Leadership, policy and responsibilities

- **Accountability:** Top management remains accountable for QMS effectiveness.
- **Integration:** QMS requirements should operate through business processes.
- **Policy:** Direction must suit purpose, support objectives and commit to improvement.
- **Roles:** Responsibilities and authorities must be assigned and understood.

Auditor application

- Seek evidence in decisions and resources
- Interview process owners
- Trace policy into objectives
- Test escalation authority

Judgement cautions

- A signed policy is not leadership
- Management representative ownership can mask gaps
- Conflicting targets undermine quality
- Unclear deputies create control failures

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Planning risks, objectives and change

- **Risks and opportunities:** Address factors that can affect intended QMS results.
- **Quality objectives:** Set relevant, measurable objectives and monitor progress.
- **Action planning:** Define what, resources, owner, timing and evaluation.
- **Change planning:** Protect QMS integrity by considering purpose, consequences, resources and roles.

Auditor application

- Trace risks into operational controls
- Test objective data definitions
- Review overdue actions
- Sample a recent planned change

Judgement cautions

- Risk registers without action are weak
- Targets can drive unintended behaviour
- Changing a form is not change management
- Opportunities need prioritisation too

Audit types, roles and independence

- **First party:** Internal audit performed for the organisation's own assurance.
- **Second party:** Customer or other interested-party audit of a provider.
- **Third party:** Independent certification or conformity-assessment audit.
- **Audit team:** Leader, auditors and technical experts collectively provide competence.

Auditor application

- Match competence to scope
- Avoid auditing one's own work
- Declare conflicts
- Use experts without delegating judgement

Judgement cautions

- Internal does not mean informal
- Independence is more than reporting line
- Technical expertise is not audit competence
- Observers must not influence evidence

Audit principles and professional conduct

- **Integrity:** Work ethically, honestly and responsibly.
- **Fair presentation:** Report truthfully, accurately and with unresolved views visible.

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- **Due professional care:** Apply diligence and judgement proportionate to importance and risk.
- **Evidence and risk:** Base conclusions on verifiable samples and focus effort where it matters.

Auditor application

- Protect confidentiality
- Maintain independence
- Document professional judgement
- Escalate immediate risks

Judgement cautions

- Audit evidence is sampled
- Courtesy does not mean avoiding hard questions
- Confidentiality applies to digital tools
- Risk focus cannot omit required coverage

Managing the audit programme

- **Objectives:** Define what assurance and improvement value the programme should provide.
- **Risks and opportunities:** Consider competence, access, technology, timing, confidentiality and change.
- **Implementation:** Set methods, resources, roles, records and individual audits.
- **Monitoring:** Evaluate delivery and outcomes, then improve the programme.

Auditor application

- Prioritise changed and high-risk processes
- Coordinate combined audits
- Review recurring findings
- Report programme performance

Judgement cautions

- Annual repetition is not risk-based
- Completion rate alone is not effectiveness
- Under-resourced audits weaken assurance
- Remote methods need their own risk review

Audit objectives, scope and criteria

- **Objectives:** State what the audit is intended to achieve.
- **Scope:** Set boundaries, locations, functions, processes and time period.
- **Criteria:** Define the requirements used as the reference for evaluation.

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- **Feasibility:** Confirm information, cooperation, time, competence and technology are adequate.

Auditor application

- Align with programme objectives
- Name virtual locations
- Use current criteria
- Resolve conflicts before fieldwork

Judgement cautions

- Objectives are not an activity list
- Scope creep threatens depth
- Criteria can include internal requirements
- Unfeasible audits should be escalated

Audit planning and working documents

- **Plan:** Translate objectives and scope into timing, people, methods and logistics.
- **Document review:** Understand the system and identify issues before fieldwork.
- **Checklist:** Prompt process-based enquiry while allowing the trail to evolve.
- **Sampling plan:** Select representative and risk-focused evidence within constraints.

Auditor application

- Sequence around process flow
- Plan opening and closing meetings
- Protect information
- Prepare contingency arrangements

Judgement cautions

- A checklist must not limit enquiry
- Copying clauses creates yes/no auditing
- Convenience samples bias conclusions
- Plans should update when evidence changes

Activity 1 — Build a Risk-Based Internal Audit Programme

Alignment: K1 · A1 · LO1 · Duration: 75 minutes

Objective: Plan audit coverage that supports strategic priorities, compliance obligations and process risks.

Scenario

Meridian Precision Services (MPS) manufactures precision assemblies and provides field calibration. Customer complaints rose after a new supplier was introduced, two

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trained inspectors left, and a major customer added traceability requirements. The leadership team wants the internal audit programme to focus on risks that could affect conformity, delivery and customer confidence rather than repeating last year's calendar.

Materials

- Context and risk register in the Activity 1 workbook
- ISO 9001 clause map supplied in the course reference pack
- Organisation chart and process inventory in the activity PDF

Activity Questions

- Which audit objectives best connect the programme to MPS strategic and quality priorities?
- Which processes should receive higher audit priority, and what evidence supports that priority?
- How will independence, competence, time and specialist support be managed?
- What programme measures will show whether the audit programme is effective?

Detailed Procedure

1. Read the MPS context, interested-party and risk information. Highlight facts that can affect QMS results; do not treat assumptions as evidence.
2. Define two or three audit programme objectives that describe the intended value of the programme, such as assurance over high-risk process controls and verification of corrective-action effectiveness.
3. List the core and support processes. Assign a risk priority using consequence, likelihood, recent change, previous findings and customer impact.
4. Select the processes to audit during the 12-month period. Explain why each is included and why any lower-risk process receives reduced coverage.
5. Set the proposed audit timing and frequency. Consider process sequence, peak workload, planned changes and availability of objective evidence.
6. Assign an audit team and confirm independence and competence. Record any technical expert or language/access support required.
7. Define programme-level resources, communication routes, records and escalation rules.
8. Choose at least three programme performance measures, including completion, timeliness, recurrence or stakeholder-value measures.
9. Peer-review another team's programme using the checklist. Challenge priorities that lack evidence or ignore major change.
10. Revise the programme and prepare a two-minute management justification for the final priorities.

Required Evidence

- Completed programme workbook
- Risk-priority rationale
- Peer-review checklist
- Management briefing notes

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Acceptance Check

Every planned audit traces to an objective and documented risk rationale; team independence and competence are explicit; no high-risk changed process is omitted without justification.

Activity files: activities/01-/README.md, workbook and printable PDF/checklist.*

Activity 2 — Translate a Process into an Audit Trail

Alignment: K1 · A1 · LO1 · Duration: 60 minutes

Objective: Use the process approach to turn inputs, activities, controls, outputs and interfaces into a focused audit trail.

Scenario

MPS accepts custom orders that require engineering review, supplier purchasing, production, inspection and delivery. Recent rework suggests that changed customer drawings do not always reach production and inspection in time. The audit must determine whether the end-to-end change flow is controlled and effective.

Materials

- Order-to-delivery narrative and sample records in the activity PDF
- Process mapping and audit-trail sheets in the workbook
- Clause and evidence prompts from the Learner Guide

Activity Questions

- Where does the process start and end, and who owns the intended result?
- Which interfaces create the greatest risk of an outdated requirement being used?
- What combination of record, interview and observation evidence would test each critical control?
- How will one sample be traced forward and backward across the process?

Detailed Procedure

11. Define the process purpose, customer, boundaries and intended output. Write the purpose as a result, not an activity label.
12. Identify suppliers and inputs, including customer specifications, regulatory needs and internal planning information.
13. Map the major process stages from enquiry review through release and delivery. Show decision points and hand-offs.
14. For each stage, identify the responsible role, control, risk and retained evidence.
15. Mark the two interfaces most likely to allow an obsolete drawing or requirement to pass downstream.
16. Select one real-looking order identifier from the scenario. Design a forward trace from requirement to delivery and a backward trace from released output to original requirement.
17. Write audit questions that ask what, how, when, who and show-me; avoid closed questions that invite only yes/no answers.

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18. Specify how evidence will be triangulated through record review, interview and observation.
19. Review the trail against the activity checklist and revise any question that lacks a clear criterion or evidence expectation.

Required Evidence

- Process map
- Control and evidence matrix
- Forward/backward audit trail
- Audit question set

Acceptance Check

The map shows clear boundaries and interfaces, and each critical audit question identifies a criterion, evidence source and trace direction.

Activity files: activities/02-/README.md, workbook and printable PDF/checklist.*

Topic 02 — Analysis and Interpretation of Audit Results

Alignment: K2 · A2 · LO2

Process trails · interviews · sampling · objective evidence · finding formulation

Audit evidence and information sources

- **Records:** Retained documented information, system data, transactions and logs.
- **Interviews:** Information from people who perform, manage or receive the process.
- **Observation:** Direct view of work, conditions, interfaces and control operation.
- **Analysis:** Patterns, reconciliations, trends and comparisons derived from reliable data.

Auditor application

- Capture identifiers and dates
- Corroborate material statements
- Keep contemporaneous notes
- Preserve confidentiality

Judgement cautions

- Interview statements alone may be weak
- Screenshots can lack context
- Copied records can be altered
- Auditor notes must remain legible

Interviewing for reliable evidence

- **Open:** Invite a process description: what happens when an order changes?

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- **Probe:** Clarify who, when, why, exception and decision logic.
- **Show me:** Move from explanation to verifiable demonstration or record.
- **Confirm:** Restate understanding and resolve contradictions respectfully.

Auditor application

- Interview where work occurs
- Use neutral wording
- Listen for hand-offs
- Close with next steps

Judgement cautions

- Leading questions bias evidence
- Why can sound accusatory
- Rapid-fire questions damage rapport
- Do not promise a finding outcome

Sampling and audit uncertainty

- **Population:** Define the complete set from which evidence could be selected.
- **Selection:** Use risk, representation, randomisation or judgement deliberately.
- **Sample:** Record size, period, identifiers and rationale.
- **Limitation:** State what the sample supports and what remains uncertain.

Auditor application

- Include recent change and exceptions
- Sample across shifts or segments
- Expand when contradictions arise
- Retain traceable sample records

Judgement cautions

- A sample is not a census
- Cherry-picking creates bias
- Small samples need cautious language
- One exception may still reveal system failure

Triangulation and corroboration

- **Convergent evidence:** Independent sources support the same conclusion.
- **Contradictory evidence:** Sources disagree and require further examination.
- **Missing evidence:** A claimed control cannot be demonstrated or retained.
- **Alternative explanation:** Test plausible interpretations before concluding.

Auditor application

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- Compare record with actual practice
- Trace source-system data
- Reconcile dates and versions
- Seek process-owner clarification

Judgement cautions

- Agreement can still repeat one bad source
- Absence of a record is not always nonconformity
- Correlation does not prove cause
- Confirmation bias narrows enquiry

Documented information and control

- **Maintain:** Information needed to support operation, such as procedures and instructions.
- **Retain:** Evidence of results achieved, such as records and approvals.
- **Create/update:** Ensure identification, format, review and approval are appropriate.
- **Control:** Manage access, distribution, storage, preservation, change and disposition.

Auditor application

- Sample current and obsolete versions
- Test external documents
- Verify access and retrieval
- Review digital audit trails

Judgement cautions

- ISO 9001 does not require a quality manual
- More documents can create more risk
- Cloud access needs confidentiality control
- Retention must meet obligations

Support processes: resources and competence

- **People:** Provide persons needed for effective process and QMS operation.
- **Infrastructure/environment:** Maintain facilities, technology and conditions needed for conformity.
- **Monitoring resources:** Ensure equipment and methods are fit for valid results.
- **Competence/awareness:** Determine needs, act, evaluate effectiveness and retain evidence.

Auditor application

- Observe workplace conditions
- Trace competence to assigned work
- Test measurement status

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- Review knowledge continuity

Judgement cautions

- Attendance is not competence
- Calibration labels are not full evidence
- Tacit knowledge can be a single point of failure
- Resource adequacy depends on results

Operational planning and customer requirements

- **Requirements:** Determine customer, implied, legal and organisational needs.
- **Review:** Confirm capability and resolve differences before commitment.
- **Planning:** Set criteria, resources, controls and evidence for provision.
- **Change:** Update information and ensure relevant people know revised requirements.

Auditor application

- Trace one changed order end-to-end
- Review commitment approvals
- Test contingency controls
- Sample customer communication

Judgement cautions

- Sales promises can become requirements
- Implied use may matter
- Emergency changes still need control
- Verbal confirmation can be weak

Design and development controls

- **Planning:** Define stages, responsibilities, interfaces, reviews and resources.
- **Inputs:** Ensure requirements are complete, unambiguous and adequate.
- **Controls:** Use review, verification and validation for their distinct purposes.
- **Outputs/change:** Meet inputs, enable provision and control later modifications.

Auditor application

- Select a design change sample
- Trace input to output
- Verify independent review where needed
- Test change impact

Judgement cautions

- Review is not verification
- Validation focuses on intended use

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- Conflicting inputs need resolution
- Software/configuration changes are design changes too

External-provider controls

- **Applicability:** Control purchased products, outsourced processes and external provision.
- **Selection:** Use defined criteria for evaluation and approval.
- **Monitoring:** Use performance and risk to adjust ongoing control.
- **Communication:** Ensure requirements are adequate before sending them.

Auditor application

- Trace a critical supplier
- Compare risk with control depth
- Review re-evaluation evidence
- Test flowed-down requirements

Judgement cautions

- Outsourcing does not transfer accountability
- Approved lists can become stale
- Price alone is insufficient
- Incoming inspection cannot fix every supplier risk

Production and service provision

- **Controlled conditions:** Use suitable instructions, people, equipment, monitoring and environment.
- **Identification/traceability:** Identify outputs and preserve unique trace where required.
- **Property/preservation:** Protect customer/provider property and output conformity.
- **Release/post-delivery:** Authorise release and control relevant delivery, support and warranty duties.

Auditor application

- Observe actual work
- Trace status and authority
- Sample special-process validation
- Review post-delivery feedback

Judgement cautions

- Work instructions should fit competence and risk
- Traceability is requirement-dependent
- Customer data is property
- Concession needs appropriate authority

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Monitoring, analysis and evaluation

- **What:** Select performance and conformity information that supports decisions.
- **How:** Use valid methods, definitions, collection and analysis.
- **When:** Set timing for collection, analysis and evaluation.
- **Use:** Evaluate customer satisfaction, process results, providers and action effectiveness.

Auditor application

- Recalculate a sample KPI
- Trace data definitions
- Segment customer information
- Follow results into actions

Judgement cautions

- Vanity metrics do not support decisions
- Averages hide variation
- Targets can be gamed
- Late data limits control

Internal audit requirement and programme

- **Planned intervals:** Audit at times determined by importance, change and previous results.
- **Programme:** Define frequency, methods, responsibilities, planning and reporting.
- **Objectivity:** Select auditors and conduct audits impartially.
- **Response:** Report results and ensure correction/corrective action without undue delay.

Auditor application

- Review programme rationale
- Test complete QMS coverage
- Follow overdue findings
- Retain programme and result evidence

Judgement cautions

- Certification audits do not replace internal audits
- Every process need not be annual
- Auditor rotation alone does not ensure competence
- Audit closure is not action effectiveness

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Management review as system evaluation

- **Inputs:** Use changes, performance, audit, satisfaction, provider and action information.
- **Suitability:** Does the QMS still fit the organisation's context and purpose?
- **Adequacy/effectiveness:** Are arrangements sufficient and achieving intended results?
- **Outputs:** Decide improvements, QMS changes and resource needs.

Auditor application

- Trace inputs to decisions
- Verify top-management participation
- Review action follow-through
- Test strategic alignment

Judgement cautions

- A presentation deck alone may not show review
- Data without evaluation is not enough
- Minutes can hide decision ownership
- Review frequency should fit change and risk

From evidence to audit conclusion

- **Criteria:** The requirement or reference against which evidence is evaluated.
- **Evidence:** Verifiable records, facts or other information relevant to criteria.
- **Finding:** Evaluation result: conformity, nonconformity or other defined outcome.
- **Conclusion:** Overall outcome after considering objectives and all findings.

Auditor application

- Calibrate team findings
- Consider positive evidence
- State scope limitations
- Answer each audit objective

Judgement cautions

- Findings are not causes
- Conclusions should not overgeneralise
- Recommendations must not compromise independence
- Disagreement should be recorded

Activity 3 — Design a Clause-to-Process Audit Checklist

Alignment: K1 · K2 · A1 · A2 · LO1 · LO2 · Duration: 60 minutes

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Objective: Create a working document that supports process-based auditing without turning the audit into a compliance questionnaire.

Scenario

MPS buys critical heat-treated components from approved suppliers. A new supplier was approved quickly after a delivery disruption. Incoming inspection found variable hardness, yet purchasing records show no change to supplier risk status or monitoring frequency.

Materials

- Supplier-control process summary and evidence list
- ISO 9001 requirement-intent map (paraphrased)
- Blank checklist and sample-plan workbook

Activity Questions

- Which process risks and requirements should the checklist prioritise?
- Which questions test effectiveness rather than the mere existence of a procedure?
- What sample size and selection logic are proportionate to the available time and risk?
- How will the auditor record both conformity and nonconformity evidence?

Detailed Procedure

20. Review the supplier-control process and identify the intended output: externally provided products that conform to requirements.
21. Select the relevant requirement themes: approval criteria, selection, monitoring, re-evaluation, communicated requirements and risk-based controls.
22. Convert each requirement theme into an open audit question linked to the actual process sequence.
23. Add a risk-focused follow-up question for each high-risk point. Ask how effectiveness is known, not only whether a document exists.
24. Define expected evidence for each question using records, interviews and observation where appropriate.
25. Create a sampling plan that covers the new supplier, one established critical supplier and one recent quality event.
26. Add fields for actual evidence, finding status, requirement reference and follow-up needed.
27. Walk through the checklist in process order and remove duplicated or leading questions.
28. Exchange checklists and conduct a usability test: another learner should be able to use it without explanation.

Required Evidence

- Completed audit checklist
- Sampling rationale
- Usability review

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- Revised final checklist

Acceptance Check

The checklist follows the process, covers the relevant requirement intent, uses open questions, includes a risk-based sample and provides space for objective evidence.

Activity files: activities/03-/README.md, workbook and printable PDF/checklist.*

Activity 4 — Conduct an Interview and Triangulate Evidence

Alignment: K2 · A2 · LO2 · Duration: 75 minutes

Objective: Collect reliable audit evidence through professional questioning, observation, record review and corroboration.

Scenario

A production operator states that updated drawings are always available at the workstation. The document controller states that obsolete copies are removed within one day. The scenario evidence includes a revision register, workstation photograph description and two production records.

Materials

- Auditor, operator, document-controller and observer role cards
- Sample revision register and production-record extracts
- Evidence-log workbook and interview-observation checklist

Activity Questions

- Which opening questions establish the process before testing a specific control?
- Which answers require follow-up evidence, and what would corroborate them?
- What is factual evidence, what is hearsay and what is an auditor inference?
- Is the evidence sufficient for a finding, or is more sampling needed?

Detailed Procedure

29. Assign the four roles and read only the role card for your assigned role.
30. The auditor prepares a short interview sequence: purpose, process walk-through, risk-based follow-up and evidence request.
31. Open the interview by confirming purpose, time and confidentiality. Use neutral language and establish rapport.
32. Ask open questions, then probe with clarify, compare, show-me and what-happens-if prompts.
33. Record exact identifiers, dates and observations. Separate quoted information from the auditor's interpretation.
34. Request and review the supplied records. Compare revision identifiers across the register, workstation and production record.
35. Triangulate the interview, record and observation evidence. Identify agreements, contradictions and gaps.

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36. State a provisional conclusion and the limitation of the sample. Decide whether an additional sample is needed.
37. The observer gives feedback on neutrality, listening, sequencing, evidence capture and time control; rotate roles if time permits.

Required Evidence

- Interview plan
- Evidence notes
- Triangulation table
- Observer feedback
- Provisional conclusion

Acceptance Check

The conclusion cites verifiable evidence from at least two sources, separates fact from inference and states any sampling limitation.

Activity files: activities/04-/README.md, workbook and printable PDF/checklist.*

Topic 03 — Risk Mitigation and Improvement Measures

Alignment: K3 · A3 · LO3

Nonconformity · containment · root cause · corrective action · reporting

Nonconforming outputs and immediate control

- **Identify:** Recognise and clearly mark nonconforming output or service status.
- **Control:** Prevent unintended use, release or delivery.
- **Disposition:** Correct, contain, return, suspend, inform or accept by authorised concession.
- **Reverify:** After correction, demonstrate conformity before release.

Auditor application

- Trace one nonconforming output
- Confirm affected population
- Review concession authority
- Check customer notification

Judgement cautions

- Containment is not corrective action
- Rework can introduce new risk
- Concession cannot override law
- Service nonconformity also needs control

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A well-formed nonconformity

- **Requirement:** Identify the exact applicable criterion and its intent.
- **Evidence:** Cite traceable facts, samples, dates and identifiers.
- **Gap:** State how the evidence does not fulfil the requirement.
- **Significance:** Apply the organisation's classification method consistently.

Auditor application

- Use neutral language
- Keep causes out of the finding
- Make traceability reproducible
- Agree factual accuracy

Judgement cautions

- Vague words weaken action
- Opinion is not evidence
- One issue should not become many duplicate findings
- Auditors should not prescribe the fix

Correction, cause and corrective action

- **Correction:** Eliminate a detected nonconformity or control its immediate effect.
- **Cause analysis:** Determine why the system allowed the issue to occur or escape.
- **Corrective action:** Eliminate or control verified causes to prevent recurrence.
- **System update:** Revise risks, processes and QMS arrangements where needed.

Auditor application

- Protect the customer first
- Use evidence to test causes
- Address contributing conditions
- Assign accountable actions

Judgement cautions

- Operator error is rarely a sufficient cause
- Training is not always corrective action
- Long action lists may dilute accountability
- Symptoms can recur through another pathway

Root-cause analysis tools

- **5 Whys:** Explore causal chains beyond the immediate event.
- **Fishbone:** Consider method, people, technology, information, environment and management.
- **Timeline:** Reconstruct events, decisions and control points.

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- **Cause validation:** Look for evidence that the proposed cause explains the failure mechanism.

Auditor application

- Use a cross-functional team
- Separate root and contributing causes
- Test alternative explanations
- Record evidence gaps

Judgement cautions

- Stopping at the fifth why is arbitrary
- Brainstormed causes are not facts
- Blame narrows analysis
- Complex issues can have interacting causes

Risk-based improvement priorities

- **Consequence:** Consider customer, safety, legal, delivery, cost and reputation effects.
- **Likelihood:** Use history, exposure, complexity, change and control reliability.
- **Control effectiveness:** Account for prevention, detection and response capability.
- **Feasibility/value:** Balance urgency, dependency, resource and expected benefit.

Auditor application

- Address immediate unacceptable risk
- Use transparent criteria
- Link action to strategic objectives
- Monitor residual risk

Judgement cautions

- A score does not replace judgement
- Severity and priority are different
- Easy actions can crowd out important work
- Risk acceptance needs authority

Corrective-action plan quality

- **Specific:** State the change, affected process and required result.
- **Owned:** Assign one accountable owner with necessary authority and resources.
- **Timed:** Set realistic due dates, milestones and escalation.
- **Evidenced:** Define completion records and effectiveness acceptance criteria.

Auditor application

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- Review unintended consequences
- Coordinate dependent actions
- Control document changes
- Communicate affected roles

Judgement cautions

- Completion is not effectiveness
- Overdue extensions need rationale
- Action owners cannot be groups
- Closing before data matures creates false assurance

Verifying effectiveness

- **Implementation:** Confirm the approved action was completed as intended.
- **Outcome:** Test whether the cause is controlled and recurrence risk reduced.
- **Sample:** Use a defined period, population and selection appropriate to risk.
- **Decision:** Close, extend, reopen, escalate or raise a new finding based on evidence.

Auditor application

- Use leading and lagging measures
- Check related processes
- Confirm no adverse effects
- Retain closure evidence

Judgement cautions

- No recurrence in a short period may mean no exposure
- Self-certification can lack independence
- A changed procedure may not be deployed
- Metrics need stable definitions

Audit reporting and management action

- **Complete:** Identify audit, scope, criteria, team, dates, coverage and deviations.
- **Accurate:** Present findings and evidence without distortion or ambiguity.
- **Concise:** Give management a clear line from assurance to priority action.
- **Controlled:** Protect confidentiality, approve distribution and retain records.

Auditor application

- Balance strengths and gaps
- State sample limitations
- Prioritise risk
- Track response and follow-up

Judgement cautions

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- Executive summaries should not hide detail
- Surprises at closing meetings erode trust
- Report approval cannot rewrite evidence
- Distribution should follow need-to-know

Activity 5 — Evaluate Evidence and Write Audit Findings

Alignment: K2 · K3 · A2 · LO2 · Duration: 75 minutes

Objective: Analyse sampled evidence, identify compliance gaps and write precise, traceable findings.

Scenario

The audit team sampled supplier approval, competence, calibration, drawing control and complaint handling. Some records show clear fulfilment, some show isolated anomalies, and others are incomplete. Management asks the team to avoid both overstatement and vague findings.

Materials

- Twelve evidence cards in the activity PDF
- Requirement-intent and finding decision guide
- Findings log with completeness checks

Activity Questions

- Which evidence is sufficient and relevant to the audit criteria?
- Which items show a confirmed non-fulfilment, and which need more evidence?
- How should the significance be described without replacing the organisation's grading rules?
- Does each finding allow a reader to reconstruct the evidence trail?

Detailed Procedure

38. Read each evidence card and record only the facts that can be verified.
39. Link each evidence item to the relevant process control and requirement intent.
40. Classify the provisional outcome as conformity, possible nonconformity, confirmed nonconformity, opportunity for improvement or insufficient evidence.
41. For each possible nonconformity, identify what additional evidence would confirm or refute the gap.
42. Write confirmed findings using four elements: requirement, objective evidence, concise statement of non-fulfilment and affected process/risk.
43. Avoid blame, causes not yet proven, unsupported adjectives and prescribed solutions.
44. Apply the organisation's finding classification criteria consistently; record the rationale separately from the factual statement.
45. Use the quality checklist to test traceability, neutrality, completeness and readability.
46. Conduct a calibration discussion: compare two teams' classifications and resolve differences using criteria and evidence.

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Required Evidence

- Evidence evaluation log
- Finding statements
- Classification rationale
- Calibration notes

Acceptance Check

Every nonconformity identifies a requirement and verifiable evidence; no finding contains an unproven cause or a mandatory solution; insufficient evidence is explicitly flagged.

Activity files: activities/05-/README.md, workbook and printable PDF/checklist.*

Activity 6 — Build a Root-Cause and Corrective-Action Plan

Alignment: K3 · A3 · LO3 · Duration: 75 minutes

Objective: Propose risk-based corrective actions that address verified causes and include effectiveness measures.

Scenario

Three work orders were produced using an obsolete drawing revision. The affected product is contained, but the organisation must determine why the control failed and prevent recurrence without assuming that 'operator error' is the root cause.

Materials

- Confirmed finding and process evidence from Activity 5
- Change-flow timeline and role information
- Corrective-action workbook with 5 Whys and cause-validation fields

Activity Questions

- What immediate correction and containment protect the customer now?
- Which causal paths are supported by evidence, and which are assumptions?
- How do the proposed actions address the system cause rather than only the symptom?
- What measure and time horizon will demonstrate effectiveness?

Detailed Procedure

47. Restate the nonconformity and identify the affected outputs, customers, records and time period.
48. Define immediate correction and containment. Assign an owner and confirm how affected product or service will be controlled.
49. Map the event timeline from receipt of the revised drawing to discovery of the obsolete revision.
50. Use 5 Whys or fishbone categories to generate possible causes across method, people, technology, information, environment and management controls.
51. Test each possible cause against evidence. Mark unsupported causes for further investigation rather than treating them as fact.

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52. Select the verified root and contributing causes and document why they explain the failure mechanism.
53. Design corrective actions that remove or control those causes. Include procedure, system, competence and monitoring changes only where evidence supports them.
54. Assess risks and unintended consequences of each proposed action before implementation.
55. Define owner, resources, due date and completion evidence for every action.
56. Define an effectiveness check with a metric, sample, acceptance criterion and review date; include escalation if ineffective.

Required Evidence

- Containment record
- Cause-analysis worksheet
- Corrective-action plan
- Risk review
- Effectiveness check

Acceptance Check

The plan distinguishes correction from corrective action, validates causes with evidence, assigns accountable actions and defines an objective effectiveness test.

Activity files: activities/06-/README.md, workbook and printable PDF/checklist.*

Topic 04 — Adherence to Compliance Standards

Alignment: K4 · A4 · LO4

Obligations · change control · procedure updates · follow-up and continual improvement

Compliance obligations and audit criteria

- **External:** Applicable statutory, regulatory, licence, contract and customer requirements.
- **Internal:** Policies, procedures, specifications, objectives and control commitments.
- **Standards:** Current adopted editions, amendments and sector-specific requirements.
- **Applicability:** Evidence-based decision on which obligations affect which processes.

Auditor application

- Maintain a requirements register
- Assign monitoring owners
- Trace changes into criteria
- Sample operational compliance

Judgement cautions

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- A legal register may be incomplete
- Customer requirements can change faster than standards
- Certification scope may not cover all operations
- Internal commitments are still audit criteria

Monitoring change triggers

- **Standards:** New editions, amendments, interpretations and transition rules.
- **Regulation:** New laws, licences, regulator guidance and enforcement expectations.
- **Business:** New products, markets, suppliers, technology, locations or organisation structure.
- **Performance:** Complaints, incidents, audit trends and ineffective actions.

Auditor application

- Use authoritative sources
- Record publication/effective dates
- Assess relevance promptly
- Escalate urgent obligations

Judgement cautions

- News alerts are not authoritative text
- Publication and effective dates differ
- No-change decisions need evidence
- Local changes can be more important than external ones

Change-impact assessment

- **Criteria:** Determine what requirements and audit references change.
- **Method:** Assess effects on programme, plan, sampling, evidence and reporting.
- **People:** Identify competence, awareness and assignment impacts.
- **Technology/records:** Review access, data integrity, cybersecurity, confidentiality and retention.

Auditor application

- Map affected artefacts
- Assess transition risk
- Define owners and deadlines
- Plan validation

Judgement cautions

- Template changes alone do not deploy behaviour
- Digital tools add confidentiality risk
- Parallel versions confuse auditors
- Emergency changes still need approval

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Controlled procedure revision

- **Draft:** Translate the change into clear, usable method and responsibilities.
- **Review/approve:** Use competent authority and resolve interface impacts.
- **Release:** Identify version, effective date, access and withdrawn copies.
- **Deploy:** Communicate, train, configure tools and retain evidence.

Auditor application

- Pilot high-impact changes
- Brief process owners
- Update working documents
- Verify access to current version

Judgement cautions

- Emailing a procedure is not awareness
- Training attendance is not competence
- Old local copies can survive
- Uncontrolled forms undermine traceability

Remote and technology-enabled auditing

- **Feasibility:** Confirm connectivity, access, identity, evidence availability and cooperation.
- **Security:** Protect confidential information, recordings, transfer and storage.
- **Authenticity:** Confirm the source and context of screen-shared or exported evidence.
- **Coverage:** Decide which objectives require physical observation or on-site access.

Auditor application

- Test tools before the audit
- Use secure transfer
- Record limitations
- Plan technical fallback

Judgement cautions

- Remote does not mean lower rigour
- Screens can hide surrounding context
- Recording may require consent
- Virtual locations belong in scope when relevant

Auditor competence through change

- **Knowledge:** Understand applicable standards, process, sector and obligations.
- **Skills:** Plan, interview, sample, analyse, use technology and communicate.

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- **Behaviour:** Demonstrate ethics, observation, adaptability and sound judgement.
- **Evaluation:** Use witnessed audits, records, feedback and continuing development.

Auditor application

- Update competence criteria
- Use technical experts selectively
- Witness revised methods
- Record development actions

Judgement cautions

- Years of experience alone are insufficient
- Certification may not cover sector context
- Tool fluency does not prove judgement
- Competence must match assigned scope

Follow-up audit decisions

- **Completion:** Was each action implemented and supported by controlled evidence?
- **Effectiveness:** Did the action reduce recurrence risk and achieve the intended result?
- **Sufficiency:** Is the sample and elapsed time enough for a reliable decision?
- **Escalation:** What happens if action is late, ineffective or creates a new risk?

Auditor application

- Plan proportionate follow-up
- Sample affected outputs
- Review trend data
- Record closure rationale

Judgement cautions

- Desk review may miss operational failure
- Closure dates should not drive weak decisions
- Repeat findings indicate system weakness
- Escalation should be pre-defined

Continual improvement of the audit programme

- **Performance:** Monitor delivery, coverage, timeliness, recurrence and stakeholder usefulness.
- **Feedback:** Use auditor, auditee and management insight without compromising independence.
- **Learning:** Analyse calibration, complaints, missed risks and technology experience.
- **Action:** Revise priorities, methods, competence and resources through PDCA.

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Auditor application

- Review programme KPIs
- Analyse systemic trends
- Share lessons across teams
- Report improvement value

Judgement cautions

- More findings do not mean better audits
- Satisfaction alone does not prove rigour
- Repeated templates can fossilise thinking
- Improvement actions need effectiveness checks

Activity 7 — Present an Audit Report and Improvement Priorities

Alignment: K2 · K4 · A3 · LO3 · Duration: 60 minutes

Objective: Communicate balanced audit conclusions and propose practical improvements that address priority risks.

Scenario

The MPS audit is complete. Evidence shows effective calibration control and strong complaint response, plus gaps in supplier re-evaluation, drawing change deployment and corrective-action effectiveness. Senior management wants a clear view of assurance, risk and action priorities.

Materials

- Consolidated findings from Activities 3-6
- Audit objectives, scope, criteria and plan
- Report template and improvement-priority matrix

Activity Questions

- What conclusion is supported about QMS conformity and effectiveness within the audit scope?
- Which positive practices should be reported to preserve a balanced view?
- Which improvements offer the highest risk reduction and business value?
- What should be agreed at the closing meeting without compromising auditor independence?

Detailed Procedure

57. Confirm the audit objectives, scope, criteria, dates, team and any deviations from the plan.
58. Summarise the process coverage and sample limitations so readers understand the boundaries of assurance.
59. Consolidate conformities, nonconformities and opportunities for improvement; remove duplicates and inconsistent terminology.

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60. Write an audit conclusion that answers the audit objectives without claiming certainty beyond the sample.
61. Prioritise improvement opportunities using risk, customer impact, feasibility and dependency.
62. Describe recommended directions or desired outcomes without designing management's corrective action for it.
63. Prepare a closing-meeting sequence: appreciation, objectives/scope, positive practices, findings, conclusion, next steps and questions.
64. Role-play the briefing. The auditee may seek clarification but the evidence and criterion should remain the basis of the finding.
65. Record agreed correction/corrective-action response dates, report distribution and follow-up arrangements.

Required Evidence

- Audit report
- Improvement-priority matrix
- Closing-meeting checklist
- Agreed follow-up record

Acceptance Check

The report is complete, traceable and balanced; conclusions stay within scope; priorities have a transparent rationale; follow-up responsibilities and dates are clear.

Activity files: activities/07-/README.md, workbook and printable PDF/checklist.*

Activity 8 — Update Audit Procedures and Verify Follow-Up

Alignment: K4 · A4 · LO4 · Duration: 60 minutes

Objective: Implement controlled changes to audit procedures and verify corrective-action effectiveness after standards, regulations or internal controls change.

Scenario

MPS receives three change triggers: ISO 19011:2026 replaces the 2018 edition, a customer adds electronic traceability requirements, and the company introduces a cloud document-control workflow. Management asks the audit function to update its method without disrupting scheduled audits.

Materials

- Change notices and affected-process summary
- Current audit procedure extract and competence matrix
- Follow-up evidence for the obsolete-drawing corrective action

Activity Questions

- Which audit documents, tools, competence needs and records are affected by each change?
- Which changes require immediate action, controlled transition or monitoring only?

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- How will the revised procedure be approved, communicated and validated before full use?
- Does the follow-up evidence demonstrate implementation and effectiveness?

Detailed Procedure

66. Log each change trigger with its source, effective date, owner and evidence of applicability.
67. Assess impact on audit objectives, criteria, programme, plan, working documents, sampling, technology, confidentiality, records and competence.
68. Prioritise the changes by compliance urgency, risk and operational dependency.
69. Define the required procedure revisions and identify the controlled documents or templates to update.
70. Assign approval, version control, communication, training and system-configuration actions.
71. Plan a pilot or validation review for the revised audit method, including success criteria and fallback arrangements.
72. Review the follow-up evidence for completion: revised workflow, access controls, competence records and sample production records.
73. Test effectiveness by comparing the defined acceptance criterion with the sample result and recurrence data.
74. Decide whether to close, extend sampling, raise a new finding or escalate. Record the evidence and decision.
75. Feed lessons into the audit programme, risk register, competence plan and management review inputs.

Required Evidence

- Change-impact assessment
- Procedure revision plan
- Competence and communication actions
- Follow-up verification record

Acceptance Check

Every change has an applicability decision and controlled implementation path; the follow-up decision is based on evidence of both completion and effectiveness.

Activity files: activities/08-/README.md, workbook and printable PDF/checklist.*

Assessment Preparation

Written Assessment (WA-SAQ): 4 open-ended questions covering K1-K4, 1 hour, open book.

Case Study (CS): one coherent scenario with 4 open-ended questions covering A1-A4, 1 hour, open book.

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Competency requires a Competent result for every assessed K and A criterion and at least 75% attendance.

Sources and Further Reading

- Tertiary course page: https://www.tertiarycourses.com.sg/wsq-iso-9001-quality-management-system-qms-internal-auditor-training.html
- TUV SUD ISO 9001:2015 Internal Auditor: https://www.tuvsud.com/en-sg/store/academy-sg/sectors/management-systems/0001-iso-9001-2015-internal-auditor
- Singapore Quality Institute course: https://www.sqi.org.sg/courses/apply-iso-9001-quality-management-system/
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